

Modern farming methods

Not only have the plants we farm changed, but modern agricultural machines help us sow, grow, and harvest crops more easily and quickly than ever before. Over the centuries, the population of the world has exploded and continues to grow. Without modern farming methods, billions of people would go hungry.

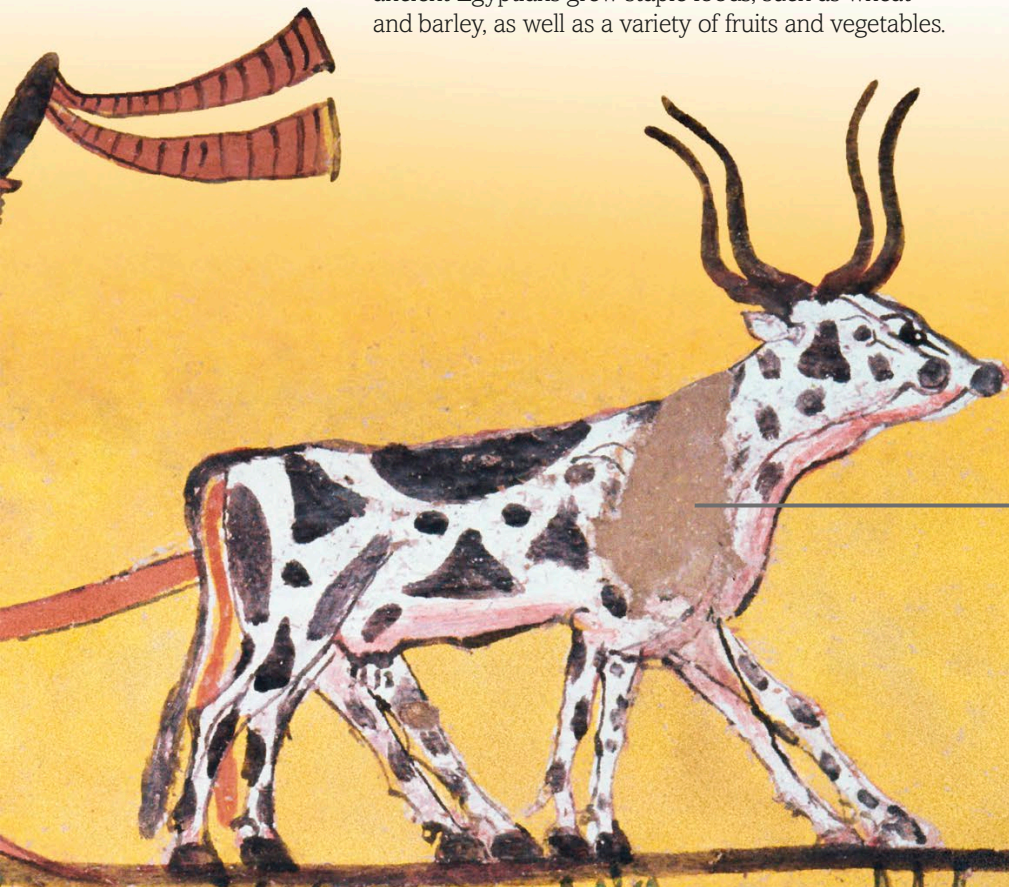
To harvest a field using a machine, the entire crop must mature at the same speed and reach a similar height.



Combine harvester

Farming in ancient Egypt

In ancient Egypt, farming began along the banks of the Nile River. Every summer the river flooded the land, leaving fields watered and rich in nutrients. Here the ancient Egyptians grew staple foods, such as wheat and barley, as well as a variety of fruits and vegetables.



Other ways people use plants

Medicine

From headaches to cancer, more than 50,000 plants around the world are used to treat diseases.



Cosmetics

Many plant-based chemicals that are fragrant or moisturizing are used in cosmetics such as shampoos and perfumes.



Furniture

Trees provide all the lumber used to make furniture. Forests must be carefully managed to replace the trees that are used.



Paper

Most paper comes from trees. Wood chips are mixed with water to make a pulp, which is flattened and dried into thin sheets.



Building materials

Lumber is also a popular building material for houses because it is strong, insulating, and environmentally friendly.



Clothes

The seed fibers of cotton and stem fibers of flax, hemp, and bamboo are often used to make fabrics.



Musical instruments

The woods of some trees can produce deep, rich sounds and have been used for centuries to make musical instruments.



Cattle-drawn plow > The first plows were pulled by people. The ancient Egyptians were the first to domesticate cattle and use them to pull heavier plows to cut tracks in the soil for sowing the seed.